AT THE GHATS



FRAGILE HILLS View of the Western Ghats from Munnar

GETTY IMAGES

considerable interests in the hills.

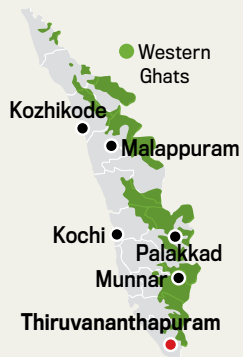
Nothing made this more clear than Congress MP from Wayanad Rahul Gandhi's three-day visit (July 1-3), which saw him join the protests. Wayanad, a Congress stronghold, has a robust farming community with plenty land adjoining forested hills. A high concentration of minorities means it's also perhaps the only seat in Kerala that can ensure Rahul's entry into the Lok Sabha in 2024. So Rahul may speak a pro-conservation language elsewhere, but here his party needs the backing of the Church, the Muslims and farmers.

If the SC-ordained 1 km buffer zone for forest areas comes into being, it will affect over 10% of the villages in Kerala

But then the CPI(M) raised the fact that it was the Manmohan Singh government's 2011 directive for a 12 km buffer zones in the Ghats that was the seed of the troubles. The Congress retorted that it was the Pinarayi Vijayan cabinet which had, in a fit of pique after the Left Front lost 19 of the 20 Lok Sabha seats in the 2019 election, informed the Centre that it was amenable to a 1 km ESZ around forest areas.

IN THE WOODS

11,521
SQ. KM
Total forest area, 29.7% of total geographical area of state



119
No. of villages affected by ESZ regulation, of the total **958** in the state

250+
Population density per sq. km in affected villages

Source: Kerala forest, revenue depts

The Left Front has since seen the folly of its ways. "The state government is proactively safeguarding farmers' interests while also protecting the ESZs. We will file a modification plea in the Supreme Court," says A.K. Saseendran, minister for forests and environment. State advocate-general K. Gopalakrishna Kurup suggests Kerala could approach the SC for the same 0-1 km relaxation on buffer zones as areas adjoining the Sanjay Gandhi National Park in Mumbai and Guindy National Park in Chennai have, since the state has 119 villages (all with 250-plus population density per sq. km) and even towns around forest areas. There's also Kerala's shape: a sliver on the map, its girth is just 120 km or so at its widest. So, with the sea on one side and the Ghats on the other, it is squashed "between the rules governing the CRZ (coastal regulation zone) and now the ESZ", as a farmers' union representative put it. But Kerala also has 11,521 sq. km of forests, including 24 wildlife sanctuaries, that fall under the category of 'protected areas'.

"Migration, mining, tourism and large-scale misuse of ecological resources have had a catastrophic effect on the Ghats. But the stakeholders are economic and political powerhouses. It's the local quarry/ tourism mafia that will be hit by the verdict. The political parties and the Church are on their side. They are drumming up support in the high ranges by putting out false information about displacement of settlers/ farmers," says conservationist Dr Shaju Thomas.

A study by the Kerala Forest Research Institute after the 2018 mega floods ascribed a lot of the subsequent landslides to unrestricted quarrying in the ecologically fragile Ghats. Kavalappara in Malappuram district, where 59 people were buried alive in an August 2019 mudslide, had 33 stone quarries within a 10-km radius. "Satellite images from Kavalappara revealed the whole landscape had changed," says scientist V. Sajeev. Since 2018, Kerala has lost more than 650 lives to floods and landslides.

After the SC verdict, states have been asked to submit a list of human habitations affected by the 1 km ruling within one year. The Kerala government has put local bodies and the revenue, forest and remote sensing department on the job. Pinarayi's pet infrastructure projects such as the high-speed K-Rail and the 1,332-km Malayora Hill Highway (SH-59) will all likely be grounded if the ESZ ruling comes into effect. ■